

VIRTUALEMPLOYEE

PROPOSAL FOR

E-Commerce Platform Development

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Date: 4th May 2026

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1 COMPANY OVERVIEW

VirtualEmployee.com is a leading remote staffing company headquartered near New Delhi, India, with five branch offices across India and one in the UK. Since 2007, VirtualEmployee.com has helped Small and Medium Businesses in 48 countries across 5 continents hire dedicated virtual employees from India in domains ranging from IT and software development to design, marketing, and finance.

2 PURPOSE OF THE DOCUMENT

Project Name

E-Commerce Platform Development

Project Type

B2C E-Commerce Platform

Problem Statement

The retail sector faces challenges in providing a seamless online shopping experience, leading to cart abandonment and lost sales. Many existing platforms lack essential features such as user-friendly navigation, secure payment processing, and effective inventory management, which are critical for customer satisfaction and retention.

Solution Summary

The proposed solution is a comprehensive e-commerce platform that integrates user registration, product catalog management, and a secure payment processing system using Stripe API. This platform will benefit online shoppers by offering a streamlined purchasing process and retailers by providing tools for inventory and order management. By addressing the gaps in current offerings, the platform aims to enhance user engagement and drive sales.

Scope And Boundaries

In Scope

- Development of user registration and login functionalities
- Implementation of a product catalog with advanced search capabilities
- Creation of a shopping cart and checkout process
- Integration of a payment gateway for secure transactions
- Establishment of an order management system for tracking purchases

Out Of Scope

- Development of mobile applications (iOS/Android) in the initial phase
- Custom hardware solutions for retail environments
- Third-party logistics integration for shipping and fulfillment

- Advanced machine learning algorithms for personalized recommendations in phase 1

Key Assumptions

- The client will provide all necessary branding and content for the platform.
- Third-party APIs, including Stripe for payment processing, will be accessible and functional.
- The infrastructure will be hosted on AWS to ensure scalability and reliability.
- The development team will have access to necessary resources and tools for implementation.
- User feedback will be collected during the MVP phase to guide future enhancements.

Document Purpose

This document serves as the binding reference for all engineering, design, and delivery decisions related to the e-commerce platform project. It outlines the requirements, scope, and expectations, ensuring that all stakeholders are aligned and informed throughout the development process.

Stakeholder Alignment

- Client: Ensures that business objectives and requirements are met.
- Development Team: Provides clear technical specifications and guidelines for implementation.
- Quality Assurance (QA): Establishes testing criteria based on documented requirements.
- Operations: Aligns on deployment and maintenance strategies for the platform.

Future Scope

- Phase 2 enhancements may include the development of a mobile application for iOS and Android platforms.
- Integration of advanced analytics tools to provide deeper insights into user behavior and sales trends.
- Implementation of a loyalty program to encourage repeat purchases and customer retention.
- Expansion of the platform to support multi-vendor capabilities, allowing third-party sellers to list products.

Closing Statement

The e-commerce platform is designed to deliver long-term value by enhancing user experience and operational efficiency for retail businesses. Its extensible architecture will allow for future enhancements and scalability, ensuring a robust return on investment as the platform grows and adapts to market demands.

3 KEY DELIVERABLES

At the end of this engagement, a fully functional B2C e-commerce platform will be delivered, featuring user registration, product catalog management, a shopping cart, secure payment processing, and an order management system. The platform will enhance user experience and operational efficiency for retail businesses, ensuring scalability and adaptability to future enhancements.

Software Deliverables

Item

User Management Module

Description

Handles user registration, authentication, and profile management, allowing users to create accounts, log in, and manage their profiles.

Acceptance Criteria

Users can register, log in, and update their profiles without errors.

Item

Product Catalog Module

Description

Enables users to browse and search for products with filtering options based on categories, price range, and ratings.

Acceptance Criteria

Users can view, filter, and search products effectively.

Item

Shopping Cart Module

Description

Allows users to add products to their cart, view total costs, and retain items for at least 24 hours.

Acceptance Criteria

Users can add items to the cart and retrieve them after 24 hours.

Item

Checkout and Payment Module

Description

Facilitates the checkout process, including payment processing through Stripe API.

Acceptance Criteria

Users can complete purchases and receive order confirmations via email.

Item

Order Management Module

Description

Enables users to track their orders and administrators to manage order statuses.

Acceptance Criteria

Users can view order history and receive real-time updates on order status.

Technical Deliverables

Item

Microservices Architecture

Description

A scalable architecture that separates concerns and allows for independent service deployment.

Format

Documented architecture diagram and service descriptions.

Item

API Documentation

Description

Comprehensive documentation of all API endpoints using Swagger.

Format

Interactive Swagger UI for developers.

Item

CI/CD Pipeline

Description

Automated pipeline for testing, building, and deploying the application.

Format

Configured GitHub Actions workflows.

Documentation Deliverables

Item

Technical Specification Document

Audience

Development Team and Operations

Format

PDF

Item

User Manual

Audience

End Users

Format

Markdown

Item

Deployment Guide

Audience

DevOps Team

Format

Confluence

Phase Milestones

Phase

Phase 1: User Management and Product Catalog

Milestone

Completion of user registration and product catalog functionalities.

Sign Off Criteria

Client reviews and approves user registration and product browsing capabilities.

Phase

Phase 2: Shopping Cart and Checkout

Milestone

Implementation of shopping cart and checkout processes.

Sign Off Criteria

Client tests and confirms successful checkout transactions.

Phase

Phase 3: Order Management

Milestone

Deployment of order management functionalities.

Sign Off Criteria

Client verifies order tracking and management features.

Out Of Scope Callout

- Development of mobile applications (iOS/Android) in the initial phase.
- Custom hardware solutions for retail environments.
- Third-party logistics integration for shipping and fulfillment.
- Advanced machine learning algorithms for personalized recommendations in phase 1.
- Integration of advanced analytics tools for user behavior insights.

The handover process will include granting access to the code repository, providing deployment credentials, conducting knowledge transfer sessions for the development and operations teams, and establishing a warranty period of 3 months for post-launch support.

4 OBJECTIVES

Primary Objective

Develop a user-friendly e-commerce platform that facilitates seamless online shopping experiences, driving customer engagement and sales growth.

Functional Objectives

- Enable registered users to complete checkout in under 3 steps with Stripe API integration, ensuring a streamlined payment process.
- Implement a product catalog that allows users to filter and search for products based on categories, price range, and ratings, enhancing product discoverability.
- Create a shopping cart that retains user selections for at least 24 hours, allowing users to return and complete their purchases without losing their items.
- Integrate an order management system that provides users with real-time order tracking and history, improving transparency and customer satisfaction.
- Allow users to submit product reviews and ratings, fostering community engagement and providing valuable feedback for product improvement.
- Enable administrators to manage inventory levels through a user-friendly dashboard, ensuring accurate stock representation and timely restocking.

Technical Objectives

- Achieve 99.9% uptime SLA by deploying the platform on AWS, utilizing auto-scaling and load balancing to handle traffic spikes effectively.
- Ensure sub-200ms API response times for all critical user interactions, optimizing database queries and leveraging caching mechanisms.
- Implement OWASP Top 10 compliance measures to enhance security, including secure user authentication and data encryption for payment transactions.
- Adopt a modular monorepo structure for code organization, allowing for easier maintenance and scalability of the platform's features.
- Utilize MongoDB's indexing capabilities to improve search performance across the product catalog, ensuring fast retrieval of search results.

Business Objectives

- Reduce cart abandonment rates by 30% within the first three months post-launch through improved user experience and streamlined checkout processes.
- Increase overall conversion rates by 20% by implementing personalized product recommendations based on user behavior and preferences.
- Enable multi-vendor capabilities in future phases, allowing third-party sellers to list products, thereby expanding the platform's product offerings and revenue streams.

Non Functional Objectives

- Ensure the platform is scalable to handle a minimum of 10,000 concurrent users during peak traffic periods, particularly during sales events.
- Achieve WCAG 2.1 compliance to ensure accessibility for users with disabilities, providing an inclusive shopping experience.
- Implement SEO best practices to enhance organic search visibility, including optimized URLs, meta tags, and structured data for product listings.
- Ensure mobile responsiveness across all devices, delivering a consistent and user-friendly experience for both mobile and desktop users.

Success Criteria

The project will be considered successful if the following criteria are met: 1) User feedback indicates a satisfaction rate of 85% or higher regarding the shopping experience; 2) The platform achieves a minimum of 1,000 registered users within the first month of launch; 3) The checkout process has a completion rate of 90% or higher; 4) The site maintains an average uptime of 99.9% over the first year; 5) Sales revenue increases by at least 15% within the first six months post-launch.

5 FEATURES AND FUNCTIONALITY

The E-Commerce Platform Development project is designed to create a comprehensive online shopping environment tailored for retail businesses and online shoppers. The feature set focuses on delivering a seamless user experience while providing essential tools for administrators to manage products, orders, and user interactions effectively.

Module List

Module Name

User Management

Description

This module handles all aspects of user registration, authentication, and profile management.

Sub Features

- As a new user, I want to register using my email and password so that I can create an account.
- As a returning user, I want to log in using my credentials to access my account.
- As a user, I want to reset my password if I forget it so that I can regain access to my account.
- As a user, I want to update my profile information, including my shipping address and payment methods.

Module Name

Product Catalog

Description

This module allows users to browse and search for products efficiently.

Sub Features

- As a user, I want to view a list of products with images, prices, and descriptions to help me make purchasing decisions.
- As a user, I want to filter products by category, price range, and ratings to find what I need quickly.
- As a user, I want to search for specific products using keywords to locate items faster.
- As a user, I want to view product details, including reviews and ratings, to assess the quality before purchasing.

Module Name

Shopping Cart

Description

This module enables users to manage their selected products before checkout.

Sub Features

- As a user, I want to add products to my shopping cart so that I can purchase multiple items at once.
- As a user, I want to view the total cost of items in my cart, including taxes and shipping, to understand my total expenditure.
- As a user, I want to remove items from my cart if I change my mind about a purchase.
- As a user, I want my cart to retain my selected items for at least 24 hours, allowing me to return and complete my purchase.

Module Name

Checkout and Payment

Description

This module facilitates the final purchase process, including payment processing.

Sub Features

- As a user, I want to proceed to checkout from my shopping cart to finalize my purchase.
- As a user, I want to select a payment method, including credit/debit cards and PayPal, to complete my transaction securely.
- As a user, I want to receive an order confirmation via email after completing my purchase for my records.
- As a user, I want to be able to apply promotional codes during checkout to receive discounts.

Module Name

Order Management

Description

This module allows users to track their orders and for administrators to manage orders.

Sub Features

- As a user, I want to view my order history to keep track of past purchases.
- As a user, I want to receive real-time updates on my order status, including shipping and delivery notifications.
- As an administrator, I want to manage and update order statuses to reflect processing, shipping, and delivery.

- As an administrator, I want to generate reports on sales and order trends to analyze business performance.

User Journey Flows

- Guest Browse Search for Products View Product Details Add to Cart Proceed to Checkout Enter Payment Information Receive Order Confirmation.
- Registered User Login View Product Catalog Filter Products Add Items to Cart Apply Promotional Code Complete Checkout Receive Email Confirmation.

The admin panel provides a comprehensive interface for managing the e-commerce platform. Administrators can manage user accounts by viewing user profiles, resetting passwords, and deactivating accounts. The order management section allows admins to view all orders, update their statuses, and handle returns or exchanges. Inventory management enables administrators to add new products, update existing product details, and track stock levels. The analytics section provides insights into sales performance, user behavior, and inventory turnover. Configuration settings allow for adjustments to payment methods, shipping options, and promotional campaigns.

Api Contracts

Auth

/auth/register, /auth/login, /auth/reset-password

Products

/products, /products/{id}, /products/search

Orders

/orders, /orders/{id}, /orders/status

Payments

/payments/checkout, /payments/confirm

Users

/users, /users/{id}

Edge Cases And Constraints

- Handle payment failures by prompting users to retry or select an alternative payment method.
- Manage out-of-stock scenarios at checkout by notifying users and suggesting similar products.
- Ensure data integrity during concurrent user sessions, especially during order processing.
- Implement session timeouts for inactive users to enhance security and protect user data.

Must Haves

Feature

User registration and login

Description

Users must be able to create accounts and log in securely to access personalized features.

Feature

Product catalog with search functionality

Description

A comprehensive product catalog must be available, allowing users to search and filter products effectively.

Feature

Shopping cart and checkout process

Description

Users must be able to add products to a shopping cart and complete the checkout process seamlessly.

Feature

Payment gateway integration

Description

The platform must integrate with Stripe API for secure payment processing.

Feature

Order management system

Description

An order management system must be in place to track and manage user orders effectively.

6 TECHNICAL APPROACH

The architecture pattern chosen for this project is a microservices architecture combined with a Backend for Frontend (BFF) approach. This pattern allows for independent scaling of services, facilitates easier integration of third-party APIs like Stripe, and provides a tailored API for the frontend, enhancing performance and user experience.

System Components

Frontend

Responsible for rendering the user interface and handling user interactions.

Backend API

Handles business logic, data processing, and communication with the database and external services.

Database

Stores user data, product information, and order history.

Cache

Improves performance by caching frequently accessed data such as product listings and user sessions.

Queue

Manages asynchronous tasks such as sending email notifications and processing payments.

Storage

Handles file uploads, such as product images and user profile pictures.

CDN

Distributes static assets globally to reduce load times for users.

Auth Service

Manages user authentication and authorization processes.

Payment Service

Integrates with Stripe API for processing payments securely.

Frontend Architecture

The frontend will be built using React due to its component-based architecture, which promotes reusability and maintainability. State management will be handled using Redux for predictable state transitions, while React Router will manage navigation within the application. A component library such as Material-UI will be utilized to ensure a consistent design and enhance user experience.

Backend Architecture

The backend will be developed using Node.js with an Express framework, following a controllers/services/repos pattern for clear separation of concerns. REST will be the chosen API style to facilitate straightforward interactions with the frontend. Middleware for logging, error handling, and request validation will be implemented to ensure robust API performance. Error handling will utilize a centralized approach to capture and respond to errors uniformly.

Database Design

MongoDB will be the primary database choice due to its flexibility in handling unstructured data and scalability. Key entities include Users, Products, Orders, and Reviews, with relationships defined through references. An indexing strategy will be implemented on frequently queried fields such as product names and categories to optimize read performance, while write patterns will be designed to accommodate high transaction volumes during peak times.

Authentication And Authorisation

The authentication flow will include user registration via email and password, with password hashing for security. Upon login, JWT tokens will be issued for session management, with refresh tokens implemented to maintain user sessions without frequent re-authentication. Role-Based Access Control (RBAC) will be established to define permissions for users and administrators, ensuring secure access to sensitive functionalities.

Payment Integration

The payment integration will utilize the Stripe API, with webhook handling to manage payment confirmations and updates. Idempotency keys will be implemented to prevent duplicate charges during retries. The system will include flows for handling refunds and failed payments, with retry logic to ensure transactions are processed reliably. Compliance with PCI-DSS will be strictly adhered to, ensuring secure handling of payment information.

Caching Strategy

API responses, particularly for product listings and user sessions, will be cached to enhance performance. A cache invalidation strategy will be employed to refresh data based on specific triggers such as product updates or inventory changes. Redis will be utilized as the caching tool due to its speed and efficiency in managing key-value pairs.

Security Hardening

Security measures will include input validation to prevent XSS and SQL injection attacks, along with rate limiting to mitigate DDoS threats. CORS policies will be configured to restrict resource sharing to trusted domains. Secrets management will be handled using environment variables, and HTTPS will be enforced across all endpoints to secure data in transit. Regular dependency scanning will be conducted to identify and address vulnerabilities in third-party libraries.

Error Handling And Observability

Structured error handling will be implemented to capture errors at various levels of the application. The logging strategy will include logging critical events, errors, and user interactions to facilitate troubleshooting. Monitoring will be set up using tools like New Relic or Datadog, with alerting thresholds defined for performance metrics and error rates. An incident response plan will be established to address critical failures promptly.

Testing Strategy

The testing pyramid will encompass unit tests with a coverage target of 80% for core functionalities, integration tests focusing on critical paths such as user registration and payment processing, and end-to-end tests covering key user journeys like checkout. Performance tests will target load handling of at least 10,000 concurrent users, while security tests will include regular OWASP scans to identify vulnerabilities.

Deployment Pipeline

The CI/CD pipeline will consist of stages: linting code for style consistency, running tests for functionality validation, building the application for production, deploying to a staging environment for final checks, conducting smoke tests to ensure stability, and finally deploying to production. Tools such as Jenkins or GitHub Actions will be utilized for automation, with environment strategies in place for development, staging, and production, including rollback mechanisms for failed deployments.

7 TECHNOLOGY STACK

Generate a technology stack STRICTLY grounded in the project brief. Do NOT add technologies not implied by the brief. Project type: E-Commerce Platform. Technologies explicitly preferred by user: React, Node.js, MongoDB, Stripe API, AWS. Must-have requirements: User registration and login, Product catalog with search functionality, Shopping cart and checkout process, Payment gateway integration, Order management system. Budget bracket: Mid - The project requires a moderate budget for technology stack, development resources, and initial marketing efforts. -- choose tools appropriate for this budget. For EACH technology provide: (1) name, (2) one-sentence rationale tied to THIS specific project. If the user specified a technology, use it exactly. Do not substitute.

Frontend

Framework

Name

React

Rationale

React will be used for building the user interface due to its component-based architecture, which allows for reusable UI components that enhance maintainability and scalability.

Ui Library

Name

Material-UI

Rationale

Material-UI will provide a consistent design language and pre-built components that accelerate development while ensuring a visually appealing user experience.

State Management

Name

Redux

Rationale

Redux will be implemented for state management to facilitate predictable state transitions and enable efficient data flow across the application.

Routing

Name

React Router

Rationale

React Router will be utilized for managing navigation within the application, allowing for a seamless user experience as users browse the product catalog and checkout.

Backend

Language

Name

Node.js

Rationale

Node.js will serve as the backend language due to its non-blocking architecture, which is ideal for handling multiple concurrent requests typical in e-commerce applications.

Framework

Name

Express

Rationale

Express will be used as the web framework to simplify the development of the RESTful API, enabling quick setup of routing and middleware for handling requests.

Orm Query Builder

Name

Mongoose

Rationale

Mongoose will be employed as the ODM for MongoDB to provide a schema-based solution that simplifies data modeling and validation for the e-commerce platform.

Validation Library

Name

Joi

Rationale

Joi will be used for input validation to ensure that all data entering the system adheres to defined schemas, enhancing data integrity and security.

Job Queue

Name

Bull

Rationale

Bull will be integrated as a job queue to manage asynchronous tasks such as sending email notifications and processing background jobs efficiently.

Api Documentation Tool

Name

Swagger

Rationale

Swagger will be utilized for API documentation, providing a clear and interactive interface for developers to understand and test the API endpoints.

Database

Primary Db

Name

MongoDB

Rationale

MongoDB will be the primary database due to its flexibility in handling unstructured data and ability to scale horizontally, which is essential for managing product catalogs and user data.

Caching And Sessions

Cache Layer

Name

Redis

Rationale

Redis will be implemented as the caching layer to improve performance by storing frequently accessed data, such as product listings and user sessions, reducing database load.

Session Store

Name

Redis

Rationale

Redis will also be used as the session store to manage user sessions efficiently, ensuring quick access and improved scalability.

Authentication

Auth Library

Name

Passport.js

Rationale

Passport.js will be used for user authentication, providing a flexible middleware that supports various authentication strategies, including local and JWT.

Jwt Library**Name**

jsonwebtoken

Rationale

jsonwebtoken will be employed to issue and verify JWT tokens for secure session management, allowing users to maintain their logged-in state across sessions.

Payment**Payment Gateway Sdk****Name**

Stripe API

Rationale

The Stripe API will be integrated for payment processing, fulfilling the requirement for secure transactions and supporting multiple payment methods during checkout.

Storage**File Media Storage Service****Name**

Amazon S3

Rationale

Amazon S3 will be utilized for file storage to manage product images and user uploads, providing scalable and durable storage solutions.

Cdn**Name**

Amazon CloudFront

Rationale

Amazon CloudFront will serve as the CDN for asset delivery, ensuring low latency and high transfer speeds for static assets across the globe.

Devops And Infrastructure

Cloud Provider

Name

AWS

Rationale

AWS will be the cloud provider for hosting the application, leveraging its services for scalability, reliability, and security in a production environment.

Containerisation

Name

Docker

Rationale

Docker will be used for containerization, allowing for consistent environments across development, testing, and production, simplifying deployment processes.

Orchestration

Name

Kubernetes

Rationale

Kubernetes will be employed for orchestration to manage containerized applications, ensuring high availability and automated scaling based on traffic demands.

Ci Cd Tool

Name

GitHub Actions

Rationale

GitHub Actions will be utilized for CI/CD to automate the build, test, and deployment processes, ensuring rapid and reliable delivery of updates.

Security Tooling

Dependency Scanner

Name

Snyk

Rationale

Snyk will be used as a dependency scanner to identify and remediate vulnerabilities in third-party libraries, ensuring the security of the application.

Secrets Manager

Name

AWS Secrets Manager

Rationale

AWS Secrets Manager will be implemented to securely store and manage sensitive information such as API keys and database credentials.

Developer Tooling

Linters

Name

ESLint

Rationale

ESLint will be used as a linter to enforce coding standards and catch errors early in the development process, improving code quality.

Formatter

Name

Prettier

Rationale

Prettier will be utilized as a code formatter to ensure consistent code style across the project, enhancing readability and maintainability.

Pre Commit Hooks

Name

Husky

Rationale

Husky will be implemented to manage pre-commit hooks, ensuring that tests and linters run before code is committed, preventing broken code from entering the repository.

Api Client

Name

Postman

Rationale

Postman will be used as an API client for testing and documenting API endpoints, facilitating collaboration among developers and ensuring API reliability.

9 TIME AND BUDGET ESTIMATE

TIME AND BUDGET ESTIMATE

Project Name

E-Commerce Platform Development

Project Type

E-Commerce Platform

Num Phases

5

Total Project Time

The E-Commerce Platform Development (E-Commerce Platform) project will be completed in 5 phase(s) and the ballpark estimate will be 6-9 months for MVP development (Mid - The project requires a moderate budget for technology stack, development resources, and initial marketing efforts.). TOTAL PROJECT TIME: Ballpark estimation will be 6-9 months for MVP development (Mid - The project requires a moderate budget for technology stack, development resources, and initial marketing efforts.) using React, Node.js, MongoDB, Stripe API, AWS, which may vary depending upon the actual complexity and requirements. This duration is based on the functionality and scope mentioned in the document (User profile management, Product reviews and ratings, Inventory management for administrators, Responsive design for mobile and desktop, Promotional codes and discounts).

Resources Required

NO. OF RESOURCES REQUIRED: Must be developed within a budget of \$100,000 - \$250,000, Must comply with local e-commerce regulations, Must support multiple payment methods.